

Three Raindrops

A raindrop was falling out of a cloud, and it said to the raindrop next to it: 'I'm the biggest and best raindrop in the whole sky!'

'You are indeed a fine raindrop,' said the second, 'but you are not nearly so beautifully shaped as I am. In my opinion it's shape that counts, and I am therefore the best raindrop in the whole sky.'

The first raindrop replied: 'Let us settle this matter once and for all.' So they asked a third raindrop to decide between them.

But the third raindrop said: 'What nonsense you're both talking! You may be a big raindrop, and you are certainly well-shaped, but, as everybody knows, it's purity that really counts, and I am purer than either of you. I am therefore the best raindrop in the whole sky!'

Well, before either of the other raindrops could reply, they all three hit the ground and became part of a very muddy puddle.

- How many characters are there in the story?
(A) 1
(B) 2
(C) 3
(D) 4
- In the sentence 'You are indeed a fine raindrop', the word 'indeed' could best be replaced by
(A) truly.
(B) never.
(C) forever.
(D) possibly.
- Who believed that size is most important for a raindrop?
(A) the writer
(B) the first raindrop
(C) the second raindrop
(D) the third raindrop



4. The third raindrop thought it was the best because it was
- (A) the purest.
 - (B) very smart.
 - (C) well-shaped.
 - (D) the most beautiful.
5. Which sentence summarises the main idea of this story?
- (A) Raindrops are living things.
 - (B) You cannot always be right.
 - (C) You should not boast about how good you are.
 - (D) It is more important to be beautiful than to be big.
6. This text is best described as
- (A) a poem.
 - (B) a comic.
 - (C) a true story.
 - (D) a moral tale.

For questions 7 and 8 choose the word CLOSEST IN MEANING to the underlined word.

7. The puzzle that Ben was trying to solve was very complicated.
- (A) difficult
 - (B) colourful
 - (C) uneven
 - (D) disorganised
8. I was satisfied when I found out that my plan had worked.
- (A) ready
 - (B) grateful
 - (C) certain
 - (D) pleased

Jungle Boy

My name is Anri. I am nine years old. I am the son of a chief, and I live near the start of the world's greatest river.

The river is the Amazon. It has more water than all the other rivers in the world put together. My tribe lives beside a much smaller river called the Cochanquinas. The Cochanquinas flows into the Amazon in the country of Peru.

Our river is usually about 400 metres wide. But when the heavy rains come, the Cochanquinas sometimes swells to become two kilometres wide, and it covers the trees. During the rains, we don't have a river in the jungle. We have a jungle in the river!

Heavy rain falls on our jungle at any time of the year, usually after a very hot day. During the afternoon, purple and black clouds fill the sky. Spears of lightning rip down. Thunder booms like great monsters roaring. Rain falls so hard, it can knock little children flat on the ground.

I live on a high bank beside the river, in huts built on top of tall poles. The poles let air blow underneath the huts, and that helps keep us cool. The poles also stop pigs or dogs or snakes from getting into our huts. And they stop the river from reaching us when the rains fall. I don't want to wake up and find myself floating away on my straw sleeping-mat!



9. The sentence 'My name is Anri.' tells the reader that Anri is the
- (A) editor.
 - (B) narrator.
 - (C) illustrator.
 - (D) photographer.
10. According to the text, what is special about the Amazon River?
- (A) It is the only river to flow through Peru.
 - (B) It has a width of 400 metres when the rains come.
 - (C) It is found near the start of the world's greatest river.
 - (D) It holds more water than all the other rivers in the world combined.
11. When the writer says 'We have a jungle in the river!', he is trying to be
- (A) rude.
 - (B) annoying.
 - (C) humorous.
 - (D) sympathetic.
12. In the text the sound of thunder is compared to the sound made by
- (A) rain.
 - (B) spears.
 - (C) children.
 - (D) monsters.
13. The fourth paragraph mainly describes
- (A) what happens during heavy rain.
 - (B) the types of houses found in Peru.
 - (C) the Cochanchinas River when it floods.
 - (D) how the people on the Amazon River live.

Meg Banana and the Mysterious Umbrella

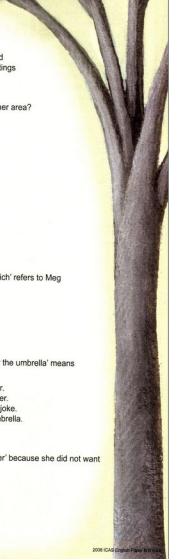


Meg Banana loved a good mystery. She didn't think there was anything more exciting than being at the centre of a truly puzzling or inexplicable event.

To solve all the mysteries in her neighbourhood Meg founded the Littletown Secret Investigators Club. She was President. She was also the only member. Meg didn't count her brother, Brian, because he only came to club meetings to eat the chocolate cake her mother baked each week. He wasn't serious about solving mysteries. But then neither was anyone else. You see, nothing ever happened in Littletown. It was so completely devoid of mystery that Meg often had to invent one herself, which wasn't much fun and got her into lots of trouble. Whenever anything went missing in Littletown, people came to Meg's house first. And they weren't interested in her clues or riddles because they didn't believe there was a mystery to solve.

Which is why they wouldn't believe her now if she told them about the black umbrella that followed her to school by day, then hung in the trees outside her bedroom at night, moaning. And why should they? Meg didn't believe it, at first. She came up with all sorts of excuses for the umbrella, like the wind was blowing it along behind her or that Brian had hung it in the tree as some sort of stupid joke. But after three days, Meg Banana couldn't resist the mystery any longer.

'Are you following me?' she asked, in barely more than a whisper, when she found it hanging in a tree outside the school one afternoon.

- 
14. What did Meg like best of all?
- (A) getting directly involved in a mystery
 - (B) seeing people enjoy a good mystery
 - (C) being excited by mysteries in her neighbourhood
 - (D) eating her mother's chocolate cake at club meetings
15. What did Meg do to try to find answers to mysteries in her area?
- (A) She joined her brother's secret club.
 - (B) She started her own investigators' club.
 - (C) She helped her mother to look for clues.
 - (D) She looked for an investigators' club to join.
16. Littletown is described in the text as
- (A) a small town with few people.
 - (B) a town with a mysterious past.
 - (C) a town where nothing much happens.
 - (D) a strange town where things often disappear.
17. In the expression 'which wasn't much fun', the word 'which' refers to Meg
- (A) finding missing things.
 - (B) getting into lots of trouble.
 - (C) being the only club member.
 - (D) inventing her own mysteries.
18. The sentence 'She came up with all sorts of excuses for the umbrella' means that Meg
- (A) tried to ignore the umbrella that was following her.
 - (B) tried to explain why the umbrella was following her.
 - (C) hoped that the mystery of the umbrella was all a joke.
 - (D) hoped that her brother knew the secret of the umbrella.
19. Meg spoke to the umbrella in 'barely more than a whisper' because she did not want
- (A) other people to solve the mystery.
 - (B) to scare the umbrella with a loud voice.
 - (C) to sound excited about what was happening.
 - (D) other people to hear her talking to an umbrella.

For questions 20 to 22 choose the correct words to complete the paragraph.

Island Ferry

Today I almost missed the ferry. I had been swimming off the rocks all day (20) I heard the sound of its horn. The ferry (21) without me! I grabbed my fishing rod, flippers and towel and raced (22) the wharf. When I arrived I was relieved to see the captain waiting for me to climb aboard.

20. (A) since
(B) but
(C) because
(D) when
21. (A) leaves
(B) is leaving
(C) was leaving
(D) will leave
22. (A) near
(B) towards
(C) before
(D) against



For questions 23 and 24 choose the sentence which is PUNCTUATED CORRECTLY.

23. (A) Jan is going to live in Tokyo with her Parents.
(B) Len told his Mum that he was going to the Zoo.
(C) Koalas and Kangaroos are very interesting Animals.
(D) Tourists who come to Australia often visit Canberra.
24. (A) 'I know where the presents are hidden!' Cried Amit.
(B) Mrs Lim said, 'Remember to bring your note home.'
(C) 'We should go for a walk tomorrow morning?' Dad said.
(D) 'I hope,' Janet said, 'That we will have fine weather today.'

For questions 25 and 26 choose the best option.

25. Mum always seems to know when my mood changes. She notices small changes in my facial expression and behaviour and knows whether I am happy or sad.

The best word to describe Mum is

- (A) curious.
(B) controlling.
(C) observant.
(D) suspicious.
26. It was the hottest day in ten years. I sweated just sitting still by the window. Even the breeze was warm and did not make me feel better. The heat _____ me.

The best word to complete the description is

- (A) teased.
(B) pursued.
(C) confused.
(D) oppressed.



Fireworks

Fireworks began with a bang when gunpowder was invented. The Chinese were the first to discover that mixing certain metals and fuels together caused an explosion. Gunpowder is a mixture of potassium nitrate, sulphur and charcoal.

A thousand years later, the Chinese filled bamboo tubes with gunpowder and threw them into fires during religious festivals. The sparks and explosions were supposed to scare away evil spirits. On Chinese New Year, thousands of little red firecrackers are let off.

In the 13th century, the explorer Marco Polo brought Chinese gunpowder to Europe. It was used to fire cannonballs, and then guns.

Today, the really big fireworks displays are generated with computers. Instead of lighting fireworks by hand, a computer program tells you how high up the firework will explode, how long it will stay in the air, and what colours it will be. The computer can even set the fireworks to explode in time to music!



Star Light

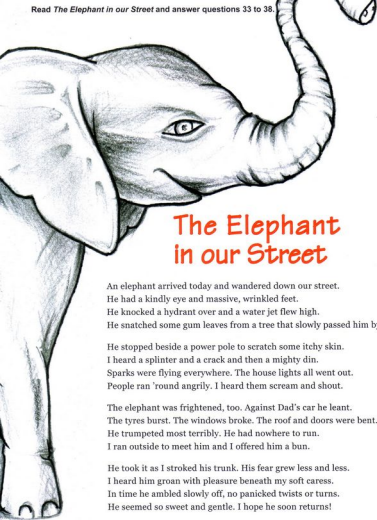
Fireworks contain a mixture of chemicals that burn well. They are made of:

- **fuel** (to keep the firework burning)
- **an oxidiser** (to make the firework easy to light)
- **a binder** (to keep everything in place)
- **chemicals** (to colour the firework, such as copper for green or sodium for yellow).

When these ingredients are mixed together, they form a ball the size of a pea. This ball is called a star. Hundreds of these stars are bunched into a container, and gunpowder is sprinkled between the stars to make the container explode. The container is then launched from a metal pipe. It has a fuse that helps it to explode when it is high in the air.

27. The words 'Fireworks began with a bang' can be read in two different ways. One way refers to the sound that fireworks make. The other way refers to
- (A) the similar sound that guns make.
 - (B) the excitement of a fireworks display.
 - (C) the fear that people have of fireworks.
 - (D) the various methods of making fireworks.
28. Why do the Chinese let off firecrackers on special occasions?
- (A) to drive evil spirits away
 - (B) to frighten their enemies
 - (C) to remember the Chinese New Year
 - (D) to signal the start of the celebrations
29. In the 13th century the Europeans used gunpowder to
- (A) power their ships.
 - (B) fire their weapons.
 - (C) make colourful fireworks.
 - (D) celebrate religious festivals.
30. What is the main idea of the fourth paragraph?
- (A) Music is the latest addition to fireworks displays.
 - (B) Fireworks are now made completely by machines.
 - (C) Chemicals are used to make the colours of fireworks.
 - (D) Modern fireworks displays are programmed on computers.
31. What is the purpose of a binder?
- (A) It allows the firework to be lit quickly and easily.
 - (B) It creates energy to keep the firework burning longer.
 - (C) It makes the colour of the firework appear much brighter.
 - (D) It helps to keep all the chemicals in the firework together.
32. Some words in the text are written in **bold** font because
- (A) they are labels for a diagram.
 - (B) they are written by a scientist.
 - (C) they highlight important information in a list.
 - (D) they show the order for adding the ingredients.





The Elephant in our Street

An elephant arrived today and wandered down our street.
He had a kindly eye and massive, wrinkled feet.
He knocked a hydrant over and a water jet flew high.
He snatched some gum leaves from a tree that slowly passed him by.

He stopped beside a power pole to scratch some itchy skin.
I heard a splinter and a crack and then a mighty din.
Sparks were flying everywhere. The house lights all went out.
People ran 'round angrily. I heard them scream and shout.

The elephant was frightened, too. Against Dad's car he leant.
The tyres burst. The windows broke. The roof and doors were bent.
He trumpeted most terribly. He had nowhere to run.
I ran outside to meet him and I offered him a bun.

He took it as I stroked his trunk. His fear grew less and less.
I heard him groan with pleasure beneath my soft caress.
In time he ambled slowly off, no panicked twists or turns.
He seemed so sweet and gentle. I hope he soon returns!

Stephen Whiteside

33. Which picture shows what happened after the elephant felt an itch?



(A)



(B)



(C)



(D)

34. The elephant could be described as being

(A) cross. (B) clumsy. (C) unhappy. (D) frightening.

35. Alliteration is the repetition of the same sounds at the beginning of words. Which of these lines from the poem uses alliteration?

(A) 'He trumpeted most terribly.'
(B) 'The roof and doors were bent.'
(C) 'His fear grew less and less.'
(D) 'beneath my soft caress'

36. Who is telling the story in this poem?

(A) Dad
(B) a child
(C) the elephant
(D) an angry person

37. Why did the narrator go up to the elephant?

(A) He wanted to calm the elephant.
(B) He wanted to know what an elephant felt like.
(C) He wanted to get a closer view of the elephant.
(D) He wanted to show the elephant the way home.

38. The poet uses many short sentences to show that

(A) the narrator is running.
(B) the elephant moves very fast.
(C) the events happen very quickly.
(D) the people have very short tempers.

THE SECRET LIFE ON YOU

Right now, you are playing host to millions of organisms, though you may not realise it. They are living on your skin and in your mouth, eyes, ears and nose—even in your bed! Each square centimetre of your skin is home to up to three million microorganisms. Most of these are helpful, providing an essential health service, but some are definitely unwelcome.

Organisms including bacteria, viruses, fungi and protozoa are normal residents on and in your body, and are called your body's normal flora*. They form an invisible army, defending you from invaders. Microorganisms that live on your skin are an essential part of your immune system. By living on your skin these bacteria are preventing other more dangerous organisms from moving in.

This invisible community on your skin may sound gross, but there is no way to remove them. Washing off the populations of bacteria on the surface of the skin only encourages microbes in the deeper layers of the skin to come to the surface.

Not all organisms living on your skin are helpful. Organisms such as parasites are generally not part of your normal flora

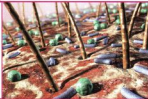
and they survive by causing you harm. Ectoparasites live on the outside of the human body and include bedbugs, fleas, lice and mites.

There are many common species of mites that affect humans. A particularly yucky species is *Sarcoptes scabiei*, otherwise known as the itch mite. This mite burrows into the skin, forming tunnels in which it lays its eggs. Itch mites cause the condition known as scabies, seen as red, itchy rashes on the hands and arms.

The dust mite, *Dermatophagoides farinae*, survives on you in a different way. These mites live in protected areas like beds and carpets and just love to munch on your dead skin cells. Humans constantly shed skin cells; in fact, you shed ten billion skin flakes a day, adding up to over two kilograms a year. All these skin flakes form dust and, luckily for us, dust is the favourite food of the dust mite. Dust mites are alive and well in your home. Your bed has about one million of them, cleaning up all your dead skin!

* Flora are plants including bacteria, fungi and other microorganisms.

No, it's not an alien landscape; it's a close-up of bacteria on your skin.



Mmm, a tasty treat. The dust mite—and a few million of his mates—just love to snack on your dead skin cells.

39. In the first paragraph the words 'even in your bed!' are intended to show that
- (A) microorganisms are found everywhere.
 - (B) most microorganisms are found in beds.
 - (C) microorganisms crawl from the body to the bed.
 - (D) microorganisms can only live on the human body.
40. Which expression in the text emphasises that some microorganisms are 'definitely unwelcome'?
- (A) 'normal residents on and in your body'
 - (B) 'This invisible community on your skin may sound gross'
 - (C) 'Not all organisms living on your skin are helpful.'
 - (D) 'Dust mites are alive and well in your home.'
41. Based on information in the text, the part of the word 'ecto' in 'Ectoparasites' means
- (A) harmful.
 - (B) external.
 - (C) ordinary.
 - (D) microscopic.
42. Why should people be glad that the dust mite exists?
- (A) It provides food for other organisms.
 - (B) It encourages skin to shed dead cells.
 - (C) It helps to clean up the dust in the house.
 - (D) It keeps harmful bacteria away from our beds.
43. In the text the asterisk (*) is used to tell the reader that
- (A) a definition is provided below.
 - (B) the word *flora* is a made-up word.
 - (C) the information that follows is important.
 - (D) there are other words with the same meaning.
44. Which of the following is an example of a metaphor?
- (A) 'They form an invisible army'
 - (B) 'deeper layers of the skin to come to the surface'
 - (C) 'This mite burrows into the skin'
 - (D) 'Humans constantly shed skin cells'
45. The first photograph shows a close-up image of bacteria on the skin. What the photograph shows might seem 'alien' because
- (A) it is similar to photographs taken in space.
 - (B) it is something that is unfamiliar to most people.
 - (C) the photograph was taken using space technology.
 - (D) the bacteria might have originated from another country.



2008 Answer Keys

International Competitions & Assessments for Schools

English

Question Number	Paper A	Paper B	Paper C	Paper D	Paper E	Paper F	Papers G & H	Papers I & J
1	D	C	D	B	C	All Correct	C	B
2	A	A	A	A	D	D	B	B
3	A	B	B	B	C	A	C	A
4	B	A	C	C	B	D	B	C
5	A	C	D	B	A	C	D	A
6	C	D	C	D	B	A	C	D
7	B	A	B	A	B	A	B	B
8	A	D	A	C	B	C	D	A
9	C	B	B	D	C	D	D	C
10	B	D	D	D	C	B	A	B
11	C	C	D	C	D	A	D	D
12	D	D	C	D	A	B	C	C
13	A	A	C	A	B	A	D	D
14	B	A	D	D	B	B	C	D
15	D	B	C	A	B	C	D	B
16	C	C	B	D	D	C	C	D
17	A	D	A	A	C	D	C	A
18	B	B	C	C	A	D	A	B
19	A	D	D	B	A	B	D	A
20	B	D	B	C	A	C	B	D
21	C	C	A	A	C	D	B	A
22	D	B	A	A	C	A	D	D
23	B	D	B	A	D	C	B	C
24	D	B	D	B	C	D	A	B
25	A	C	C	B	D	A	A	C
26	B	D	C	B	D	B	C	C
27	C	B	B	D	A	D	D	D
28	C	A	A	C	A	B	A	D
29	C or D	B	D	A	D	C	B	D
30	C	D	B	C	C	C	B	B
31	B	D	D	B	B	D	A	C
32	D	C	C	B	C	B	B	C
33	B	D	B	C	B	C	A	A
34	D	B	D	D	D	B	A	A
35	A	A	A	D	C	A	D	D
36	C	B	D	C	B	B	A	A
37	D	A	A	A	A	B	C	A
38	B	C	C	D	A	B	B	A
39	D	A	B	A	A	D	B	C
40	A	C	C	B	C	B	D	D

(Please turn over)

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Question Number	Paper A	Paper B	Paper C	Paper D	Paper E	Paper F	Papers G & H	Papers I & J
					D	A	A	B
41	D	B	A	D	B	A	B	C
42	C	C	A	C	A	C	A	B
43	A	A	A	D	D	B	C	A
44	C	A	B	A	B	C	B	C
45	B	B	C	B	A	D	A	D
46			B	B	D	C	C	C
47			C	C	D	D	A	A
48			D	A	D	C	C	A
49			D	C	B	A	D	C
50			A	B	A	A	C	B
51					A	A	A	D
52					D	A	A	C
53					A	C	A	C
54					B	B	C	B
55					C	C	A	B
56							D	A
57							D	B
58							D	D
59							C	B
60							C	A

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